

FAMOUS INDIAN PAINTINGS



1. “Bapuji” By Nandalal Bose

Mahatma Gandhi may be well-known as a notable liberation fighter, but few are aware that many modern artists, including Nandalal Bose, found inspiration in him. Bose’s 1930 ‘Dandi March’ linocut picture, which bears the caption ‘Bapuji, 1930,’ is a monument to his strong respect for Gandhi and is on permanent display in the National Gallery of Modern Art in Delhi.



2. “Shakuntala” By Raja Ravi Varma

Raja Ravi Varma, known as the father of modern Indian art, painted “Shakuntala,” a masterpiece inspired by Kalidasa’s famous play. This romantic and evocative painting showcases his mastery of the oil-on-canvas technique.

It’s a modern retelling of the Shakuntala looking for Dushyanta in the epic Mahabharatha. As in the story, this painting depicts Shakuntala pretending to remove a thorn from her foot but she’s looking yonder to see where her lover Dushyanta is. Her friends are casually talking near her, and a mysterious hooded figure is walking with a cane in the background.

There is a lyrical beauty and sensuality in the way Shakuntala is posed in this painting, which perfectly matches the joyous and colourful atmosphere of the overall picture.



3. “Mother India” By Amrita Sher-Gil

Amrita Sher-Gil, often referred to as India's Frida Kahlo, painted “Mother India,” a striking portrayal of the maternal figure representing the spirit and resilience of the nation. This painting is a symbol of India's cultural identity. The faces of her subject at this time have their faces and stances steeped in melancholy and are marked by large, sad eyes.



4. “Untitled (Falling Figure)” By Tyeb Mehta

Tyeb Mehta's “Falling Figure” is a powerful representation of existentialism. This artwork reflects the tumultuous emotions and struggles faced by individuals in a rapidly changing society.

Mehta's investigation of the topic *The Falling Figure* during this time was inspired by a disturbing childhood memory he retained of seeing a man violently killed during the Subcontinent's deadly Partition riots in 1947.

The subsequent racial confrontations had a long-lasting effect on his life and work. Dilip Chitre, a poet and a friend of the artist, said this about the incident: “When Mehta resided on Mohammed Ali Road in South Mumbai, he observed a man being cut and slain by rioting people from his window.

Mehta asserts that this one violent vision, which he actually experienced in person, is the source of all of the uncertainty he had about India, including the uncertainty of independence, the uncertainty of intercommunal interactions, and everything else.

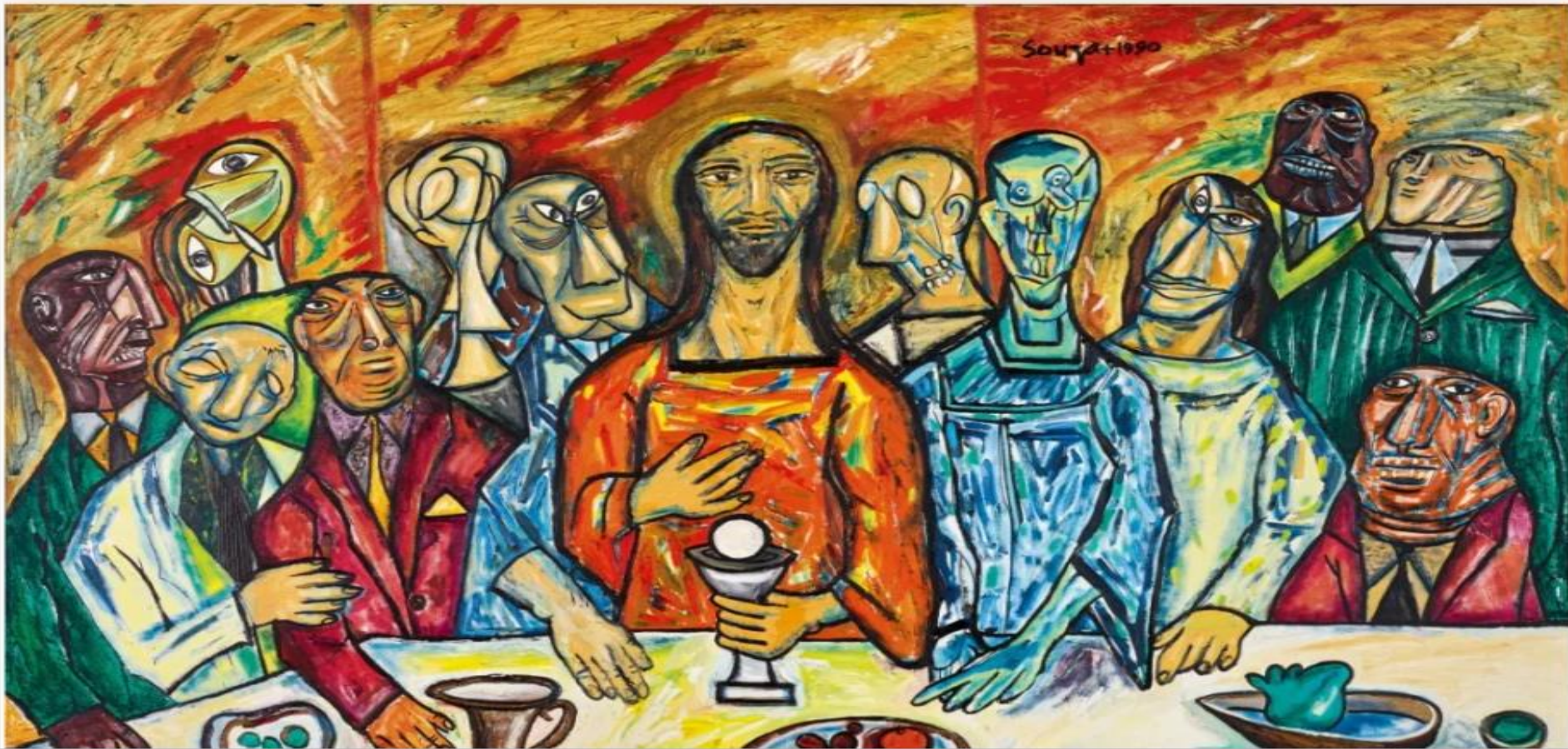


5. “The Last Supper” By Francis Newton Souza

Francis Newton Souza's reinterpretation of “The Last Supper” reflects his unique artistic voice. The painting explores themes of spirituality, sexuality, and human connection in a thought-provoking manner.

Some of Souza's most renowned works, like *Crucifixion* (1959), in which Christ is seen in agonising torment on the cross, and *Deposition* (1963), in which Christ's crucified, bleeding body is moved for burial, reflect the events after the Last Supper.

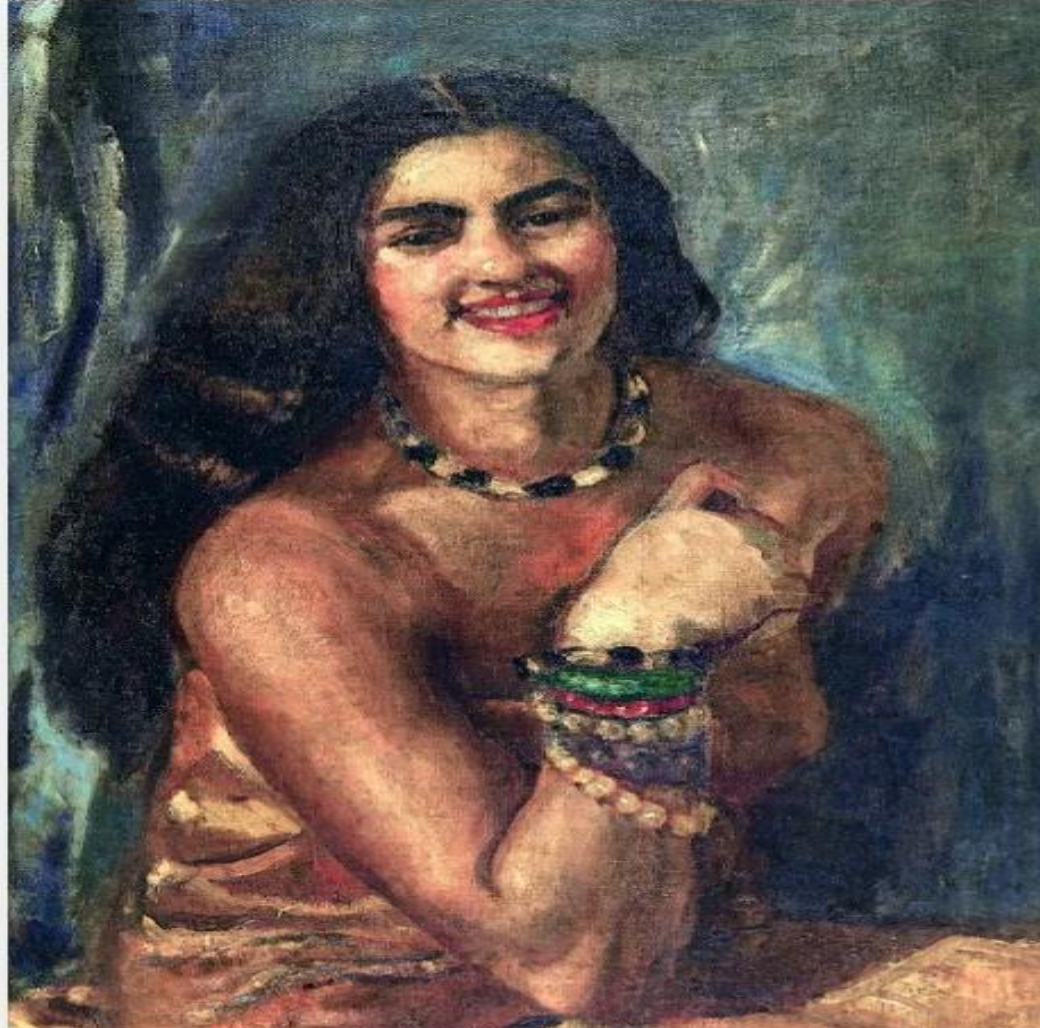
Furthermore, Souza regularly depicted the Last Supper as the foundation of the Catholic tradition of the Eucharist in his still-life paintings from the mid-1950s to the early 1960s, which feature a variety of liturgical artefacts arranged on a table. Years later, Souza depicts the Last Supper to emphasise the significance of this event for Catholicism and his own artistic output.



6. “Self Portrait” By Amrita Sher-Gil

Amrita Sher-Gil's “Self Portrait” is a remarkable example of her introspective style. This self-portrait captures her self-exploration and vulnerability as an artist.

From 1930 onwards, Amrita Sher-Gil painted a series of self-portraits representing her many moods. This seductive and exuberant mood that she has captured is relatively rare in her series of self-portraits.



7. “Untitled (Bird In Space)” By S.H. Raza

S.H. Raza, a pioneer of Indian modern art, created “Untitled (Bird In Space),” which is a representation of his “Bindu” philosophy. The painting is a blend of abstract and spiritual elements, emphasizing unity and transcendence.

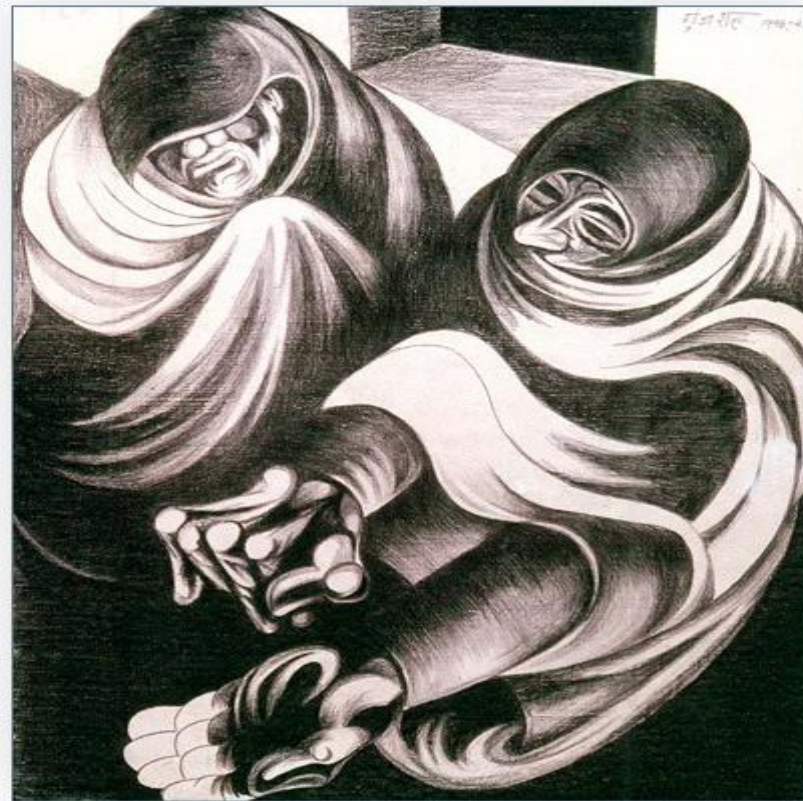


8. “Jallianwala Bagh” By Satish Gujral

Satish Gujral's “Jallianwala Bagh” is a haunting depiction of the tragic massacre in 1919. This painting serves as a poignant reminder of a dark chapter in Indian history.

The 1947 Partition of India significantly impacted Satish Gujral's early career as a painter. Not only was he an unwilling witness to cruel acts of man against man, but also, he had been there along with his father to help those Hindu refugees from his hometown in Jhelum to immigrate to India. The bloody scenes inspired him to create a series of Partition paintings.

The war victims' agony was depicted through his brush. Later, the artist confessed, “I didn't paint Partition, but I painted my own suffering.” (Shilpa, 2017). His life turned brighter when Satish Gujral met and married Kiran. She becomes his muse and brings colour into his posterior works.



9. "Self-Portrait" By Rabindranath Tagore

Rabindranath's earliest visual work appeared in his manuscripts of poems (eg. Purabi) and comprised of doodles, scribbles and erasures made out of unwanted words and lines.

Towards the end of his career, Tagore aged 67, striving to create a universally accessible art, took up painting more consistently. Around 1928, the artist made thousands of sketches and drawings using brush, pencil and pen. The artist developed a style characterised by simple bold forms and a rhythmic quality. The subjects depicted often involved animals, figures and statuesque women.

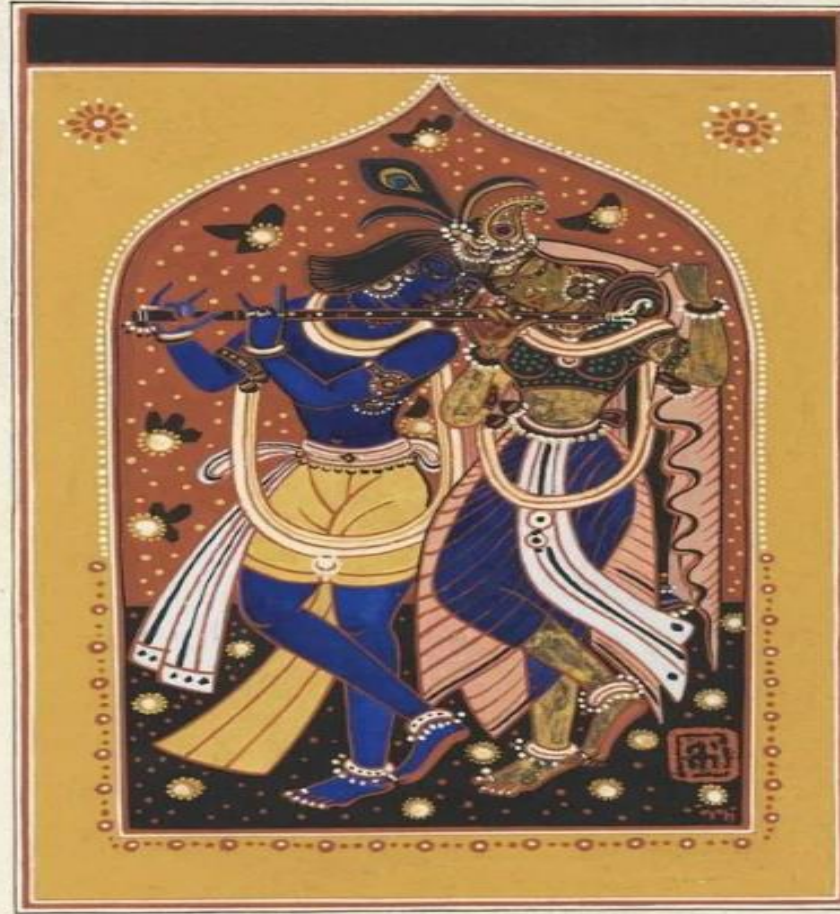
This painting depicts the full-face, self-portrait of the bearded artist. The unworked background and the enhanced contour push the figure out from the ground. The flatness of the figure is enhanced by the lack of colour and the use of rough pencil lines.



10. “Krishna And Radha” By Nandalal Bose

Nandalal Bose was one of the pioneers of modern Indian art and a key figure of Contextual Modernism. A pupil of Abanindranath Tagore, Bose was known for his “Indian style” of painting. He became the principal of Kala Bhavan, Santiniketan in 1922.

The last of the 10 World Famous Paintings by Indian Artists includes Nandalal Bose’s “Krishna and Radha” is a mesmerizing portrayal of divine love. This artwork beautifully blends traditional Indian art forms with a modern touch.



RAJA RAVI VARMA

- His works are one of the best examples of the fusion of European academic art with a purely Indian sensibility and iconography. He greatly enhanced his reach and influence as a painter and public figure by making affordable lithographs of his paintings available to the public. His lithographs increased the involvement of common people with fine arts and defined artistic tastes. Furthermore, his religious depictions of Hindu deities and works from Indian epic poetry and Puranas have received critical acclaim. He was part of the royal family of Parappanad, Malappuram district.



Shakuntala



Woman Holding a Fruit
1900



Hamsa Damayanti



Damayanti
1895



Yashoda Krishna
1895



Galaxy of Musicians
1889



The Milkmaid.



There Comes Papa
1893

AMRITA SHER-GIL



- "one of the greatest avant-garde women artists of the early 20th century" and a pioneer in modern Indian art.
- She first gained recognition at the age of 19, for her 1932 oil painting *Young Girls*. Sher-Gil depicted everyday life of the people in her paintings.
- She was also an avid reader and a pianist. Sher-Gil's paintings are among the most expensive by Indian women painters today, although few acknowledged her work when she was alive.
- In 1941, at age 28, just days before the opening of her first major solo show in Lahore, Sher-Gil became seriously ill and slipped into a coma
- died around midnight on 5 December 1941

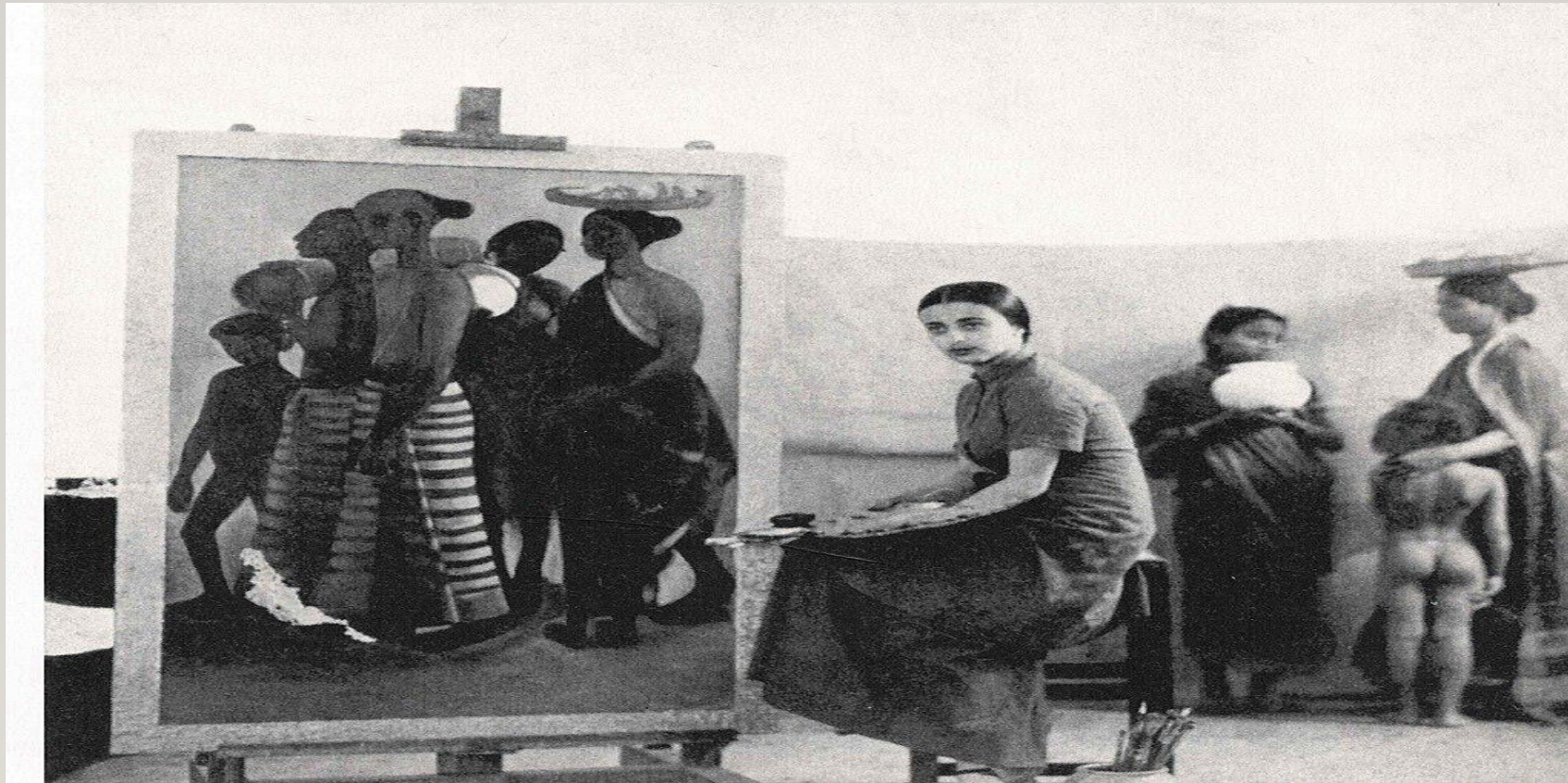
***YOUNG GIRLS*, 1932, OIL ON CANVAS**



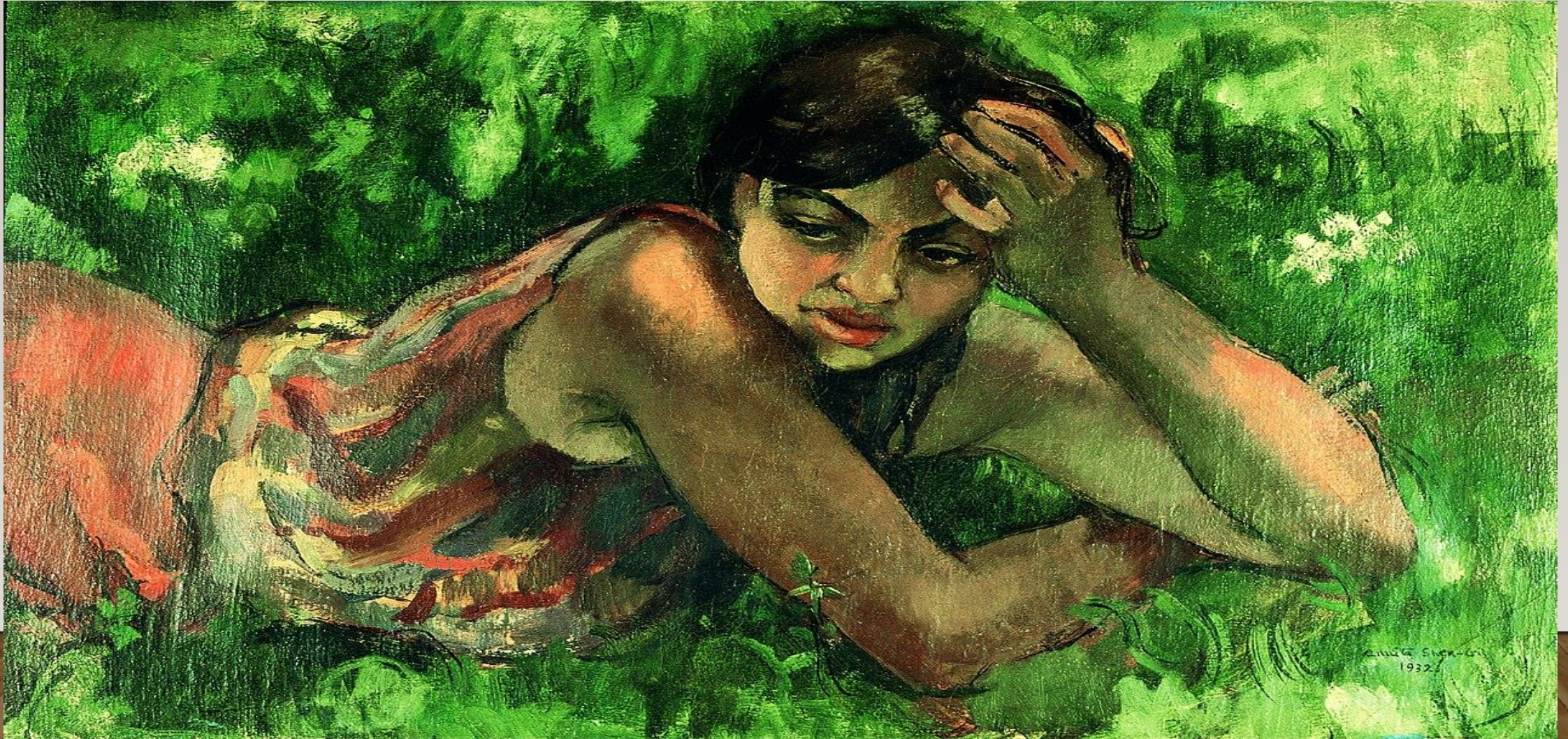
SOUTH INDIAN VILLAGERS GOING TO MARKET, 1937.



**SHER-GIL PAINTING SOUTH INDIAN VILLAGERS
GOING TO MARKET WITH THREE OF ITS MODELS,
PHOTOGRAPHED IN 1937 AT HER HOME IN
SIMLA.**



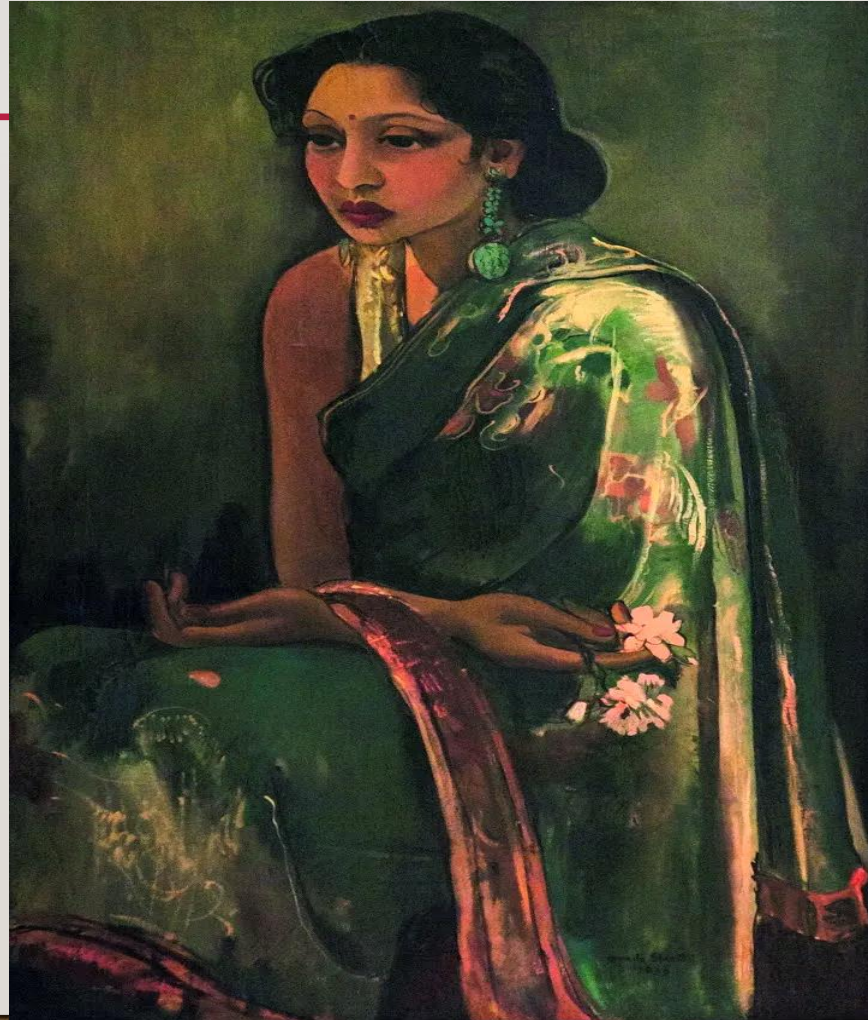
HUNGARIAN GYPSY GIRL, 1932



GROUP OF THREE GIRLS, 1935



SUMMER, 1936



BRIDE'S TOILET, 1937



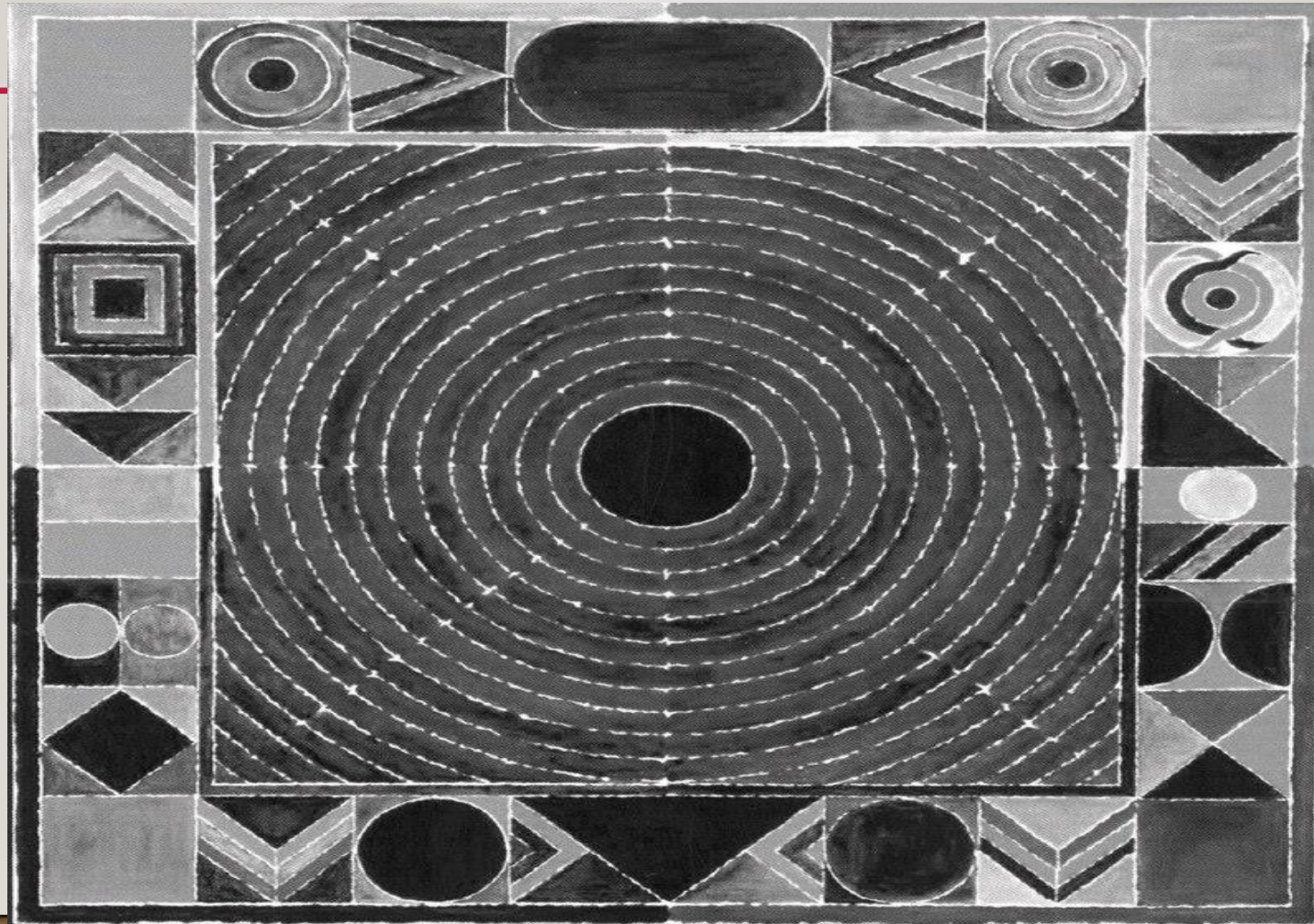
VILLAGE SCENE, 1938



S. H. RAZA

- was an Indian painter who lived and worked in France for most of his career.
- He was awarded the Padma Shri in 1981, Fellowship of the Lalit Kala Academi in 1984, Padma Bhushan in 2007, and Padma Vibhushan in 2013 He was conferred with the *Commandeur de la Légion d'honneur* (Legion of Honour) on 14 July 2015
- His seminal work *Saurashtra* sold for ₹16.42 crore (\$3,486,965) at a Christie's auction in 2010

BLACK SUN BASED ON BINDU BY S. H. RAZA





Saurashtra
1983



Clocher du Village
1958



Ankuran
1987



Saison I
1966



Ciel Rouge Sur Le Lac
1961



Bindu La Terre
1983



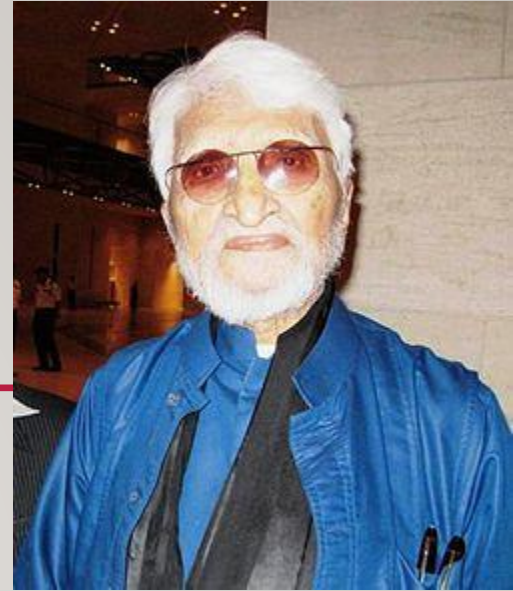
Composition Geome...
2007



Surya Namaskar

M. F. HUSAIN

- He was one of the founding members of Bombay Progressive Artists' Group
- M.F. Husain is associated with Indian modernism in the 1940s.
- His narrative paintings, executed in a modified Cubist style, can be caustic and funny as well as serious and sombre. His themes—sometimes treated in series—included topics as diverse as Gandhi, Mother Teresa, the Ramayana, the Mahabharata, the British Raj and motifs of Indian urban and rural life. In September 2020, his painting titled “Voices”, auctioned for a record \$2.5 million.





Living Goddess
1960



The Volodarsky Husain



Mahabharata
1988



Woman in Red



Bhishma
1988



Allah
2010



The Lost Princesses
1964



Camel
1950



Drawing
1964



Horses
1960



Untitled (Woman at ...
1958



Mother Teresa
1989



Ganga and Jamuna
1988



Lady with Veena
1979



Untitled (Portrait of C...
1957



British Raj
2009



Rajasthani Women
1960



Red Landscape
1964



Rajasthan Landscape
1962



Blue Nursery with B...
1946



Portrait of Jamini Roy



Title Unknown



Cyclonic Silence
1977



Untitled (Portrait of I...
1979

M.F. Husain "Horses"



JAMINI ROY

- **He remains one of the most famous pupils of Abanindranath Tagore, another praised Indian artist and instructor**

Roy's highly simplified, flattened-out style, and reminiscent of European modern art was influenced by the “bazaar” paintings sold at Indian temples as talismans



Durga and Ganesha III, Jamini R...

 Dessine Art



Jamini Roy Wall Painting...

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Jamini Roy | Modern ...

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Painting of Dancing ...

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Handmaiden, Jamini Roy ...

 Dessine Art



Jamini Roy - Overvie...

 Grosvenor Galle...



Jamini Roy: Life, Pain...

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Jamini Roy Paintings ...

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Jamini Roy | Modern and Contemp...

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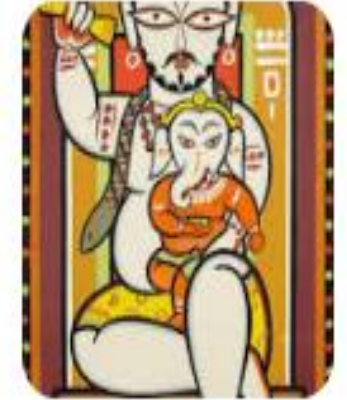
Jamini Roy- An Artist...

 Akar Prakar



Kalighat painting in Jami...

 Mojarto



Jamini Roy Paintings ...

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TYEB MEHTA



Untitled
1973



Untold Element
1965



The Rickshaw Puller
1982



Celebration



Untitled (Santiniketa...
1987



Thrown Bull



Drummer
2000



Diagonal, 1973

NANDALAL BOSE

In 1976, the archaeological survey of india, department of culture, govt. of India declared his works among the "nine artists" whose work, "not being antiquities", were to be henceforth considered "to be art treasures, having regard to their artistic and aesthetic value".
He was given the work of illustrating the constitution of India.

RABINDRANATH TAGORE

- also known by his pseudonym **Bhanusimha** or **Gurudev** was a Bengali polymath who worked as a poet, writer, playwright, composer, philosopher, social reformer, and painter of the Bengal Renaissance
- He was the author of the "profoundly sensitive, fresh and beautiful" poetry of *Gitanjali*
- In 1913, Tagore became the first non-European to win a Nobel Prize in any category, and also the first lyricist to win the Nobel Prize in Literature. Tagore's poetic songs were viewed as spiritual and mercurial; his elegant prose and magical poetry were widely popular in the Indian subcontinent.
- He was a fellow of the Royal Asiatic Society.
- Referred to as "the Bard of Bengal" Tagore was known by the sobriquets **Gurudev**, **Kobiguru**, and **Biswokobi**.



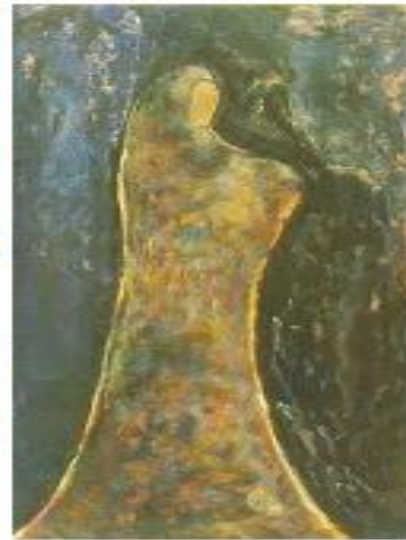
Dancing Woman
1940



Head Study (Geome...
1929



Woman's Face
1931



Standing Figure



Rabindranath Tagor...



Bird (Fantastic)



Seven Figures



Brooding

ABANINDRANATH TAGORE

- an Indian painter who was the principal artist and creator of the Indian Society of Oriental Art in 1907.
-
- He was also the first major exponent of Swadeshi values in Indian art
 - .He founded the influential Bengal school of art, which led to the development of modern Indian painting
 - He was also a noted writer, particularly for children. Popularly known as 'Aban Thakur', his books *Rajkahini*, *Buro Angla*, *Nalak*, and *Khirer Putul* were landmarks in Bengali language children's literature and art.

ANJOLIE ELA MENON

- In 2006, her triptych work "Yatra" was acquired by the Asian Art Museum of San Francisco. Other works have also been a part of group exhibitions including 'Kalpana: Figurative Art in India', presented by the Indian Council for Cultural Relations (ICCR) in London's Aicon Gallery in 2009. Her preferred medium is oil on Masonite though she has also worked in other media, including Murano glass, computer graphics and water colour. She is a well known muralist.
- She was awarded the Padma Shree in 2000.
- She lives and works in New Delhi.





Bharat Mata
1905



Asoka's Queen
1910



The Passing of Shah...
1902



My Mother
1913



Krishna as cowboy
1897



Birth of Krishna
1897

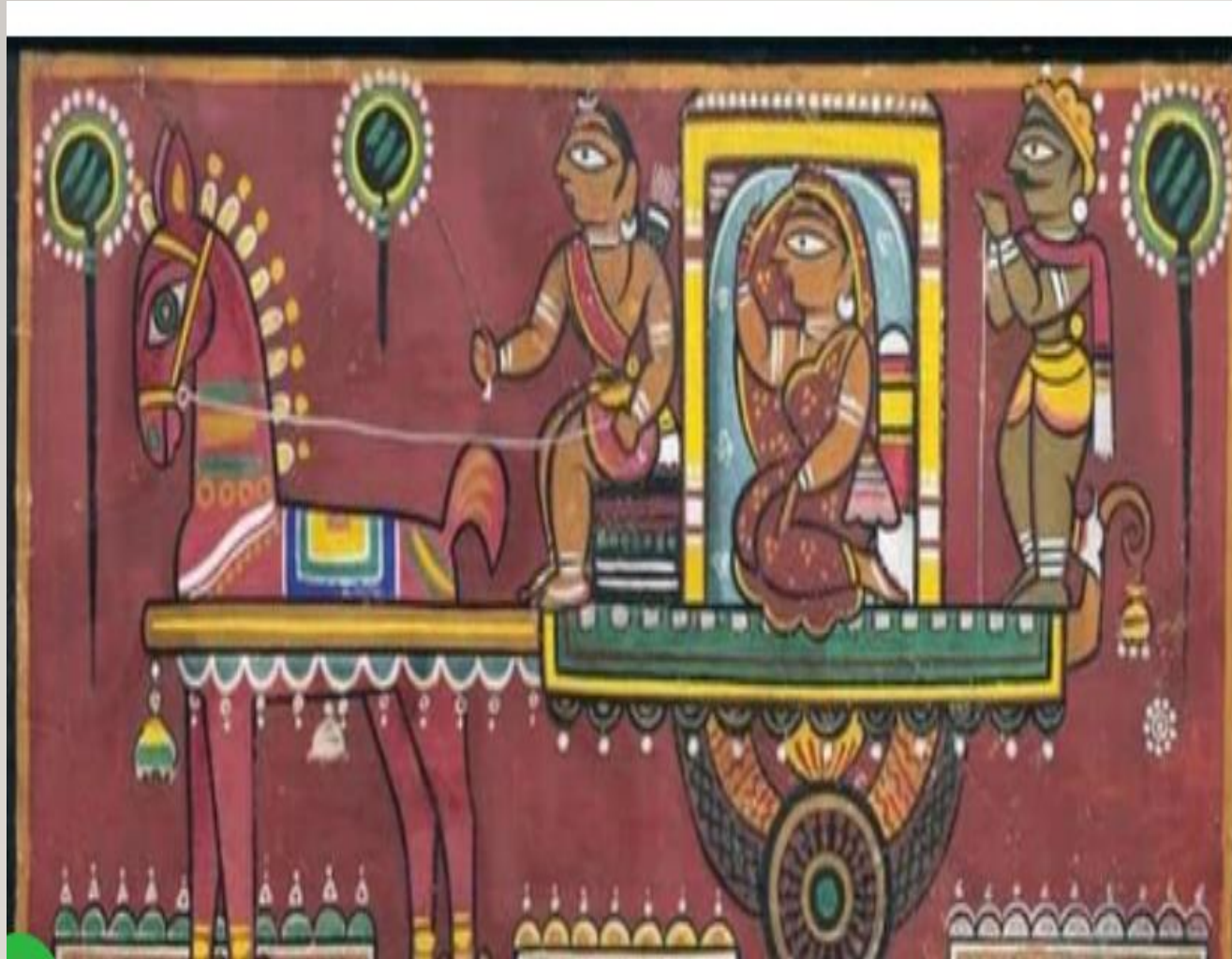


Ganesh Janani



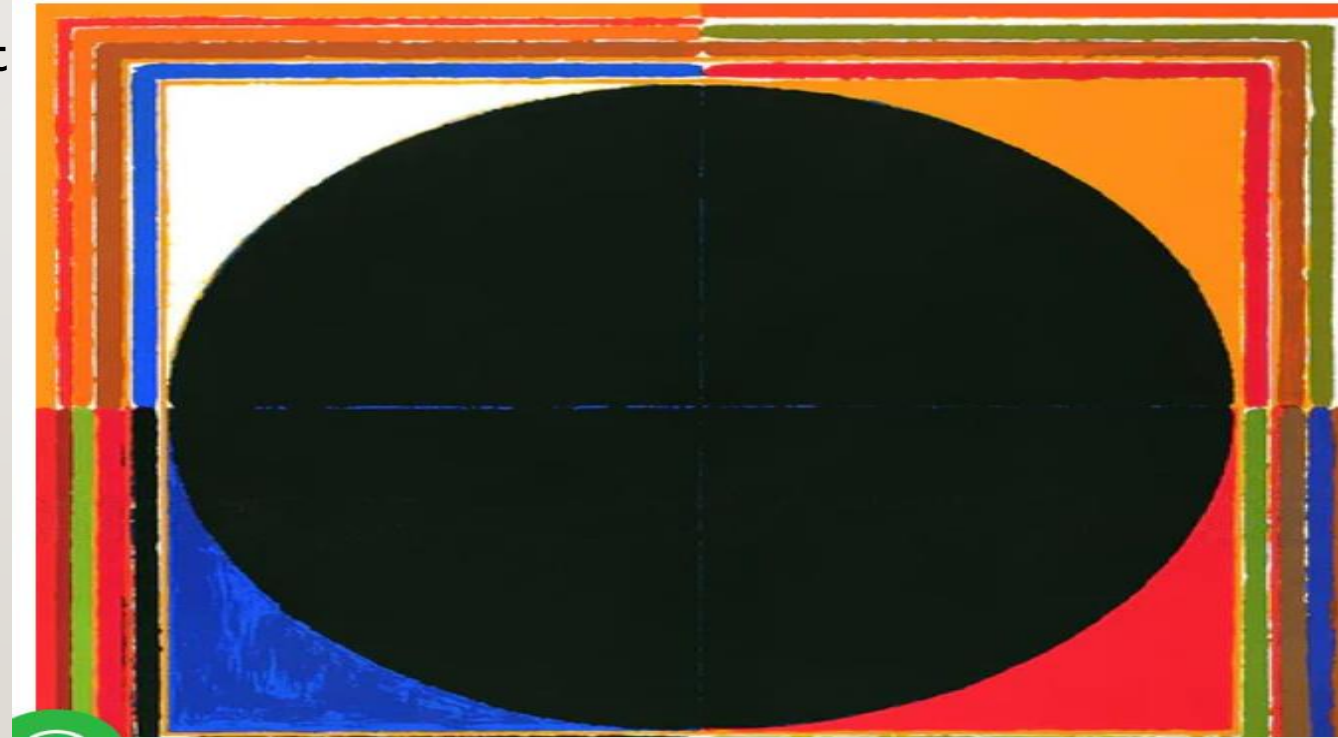
Emperor's March to ...

Jamini roy - "Bride and Two Companions"



S.H. RAZA - "BINDU"

- S.H. The "Bindu" Series by Raza is a celebration the Indian concept Bindu, which represents the point of creation in the infinite universe.
- The series features geometric patterns in vibrant colors that reflect Raza's philosophical and spiritual explorations. The term "Bindu" is synonymous with Raza, expressing his unique blend between Indian heritage and modernist abstract



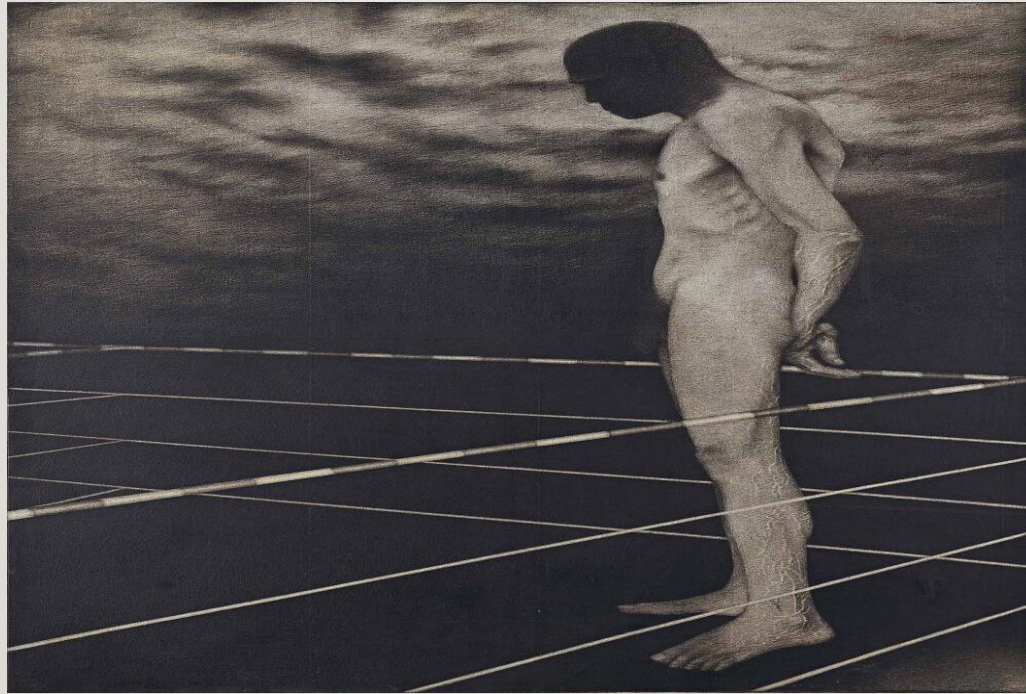
TYEB MEHTA - "MAHISHASURA"

- Tyeb Mehta's "Mahishasura", a powerful portrayal of the mythological demonic being slain, is an impressive depiction. The painting is noted for its bold, fragmented color scheme and stark style. This piece is a standout among contemporary Indian art because of Mehta's unique compositional style and ability to convey strong emotions.



RAMESHWAR BROOTA - "MAN SERIES"

- Rameshwar Broota's meticulous technique and deep thematic explorations of human existence are well known. In his "Man Series", Rameshwar Broota explores the fragility and vulnerability in the human form, which is often shown with stark monochromatic shades. Broota uses the scraping method, in which he applies paint and then scrapes it off, to add texture and depth.



SUBODH GUPTA - "SAAT SAMUNDAR PAAR"

- Subodh Gupta's art is renowned for its use of everyday items, which reflects the socio-economic change in India. The striking installation "Saat Samundar Paar", created with stainless steel utensils, is a stunning work. The painting version captures the essence and diaspora of global migration. It highlights Gupta's ability to transform everyday objects into powerful statements.



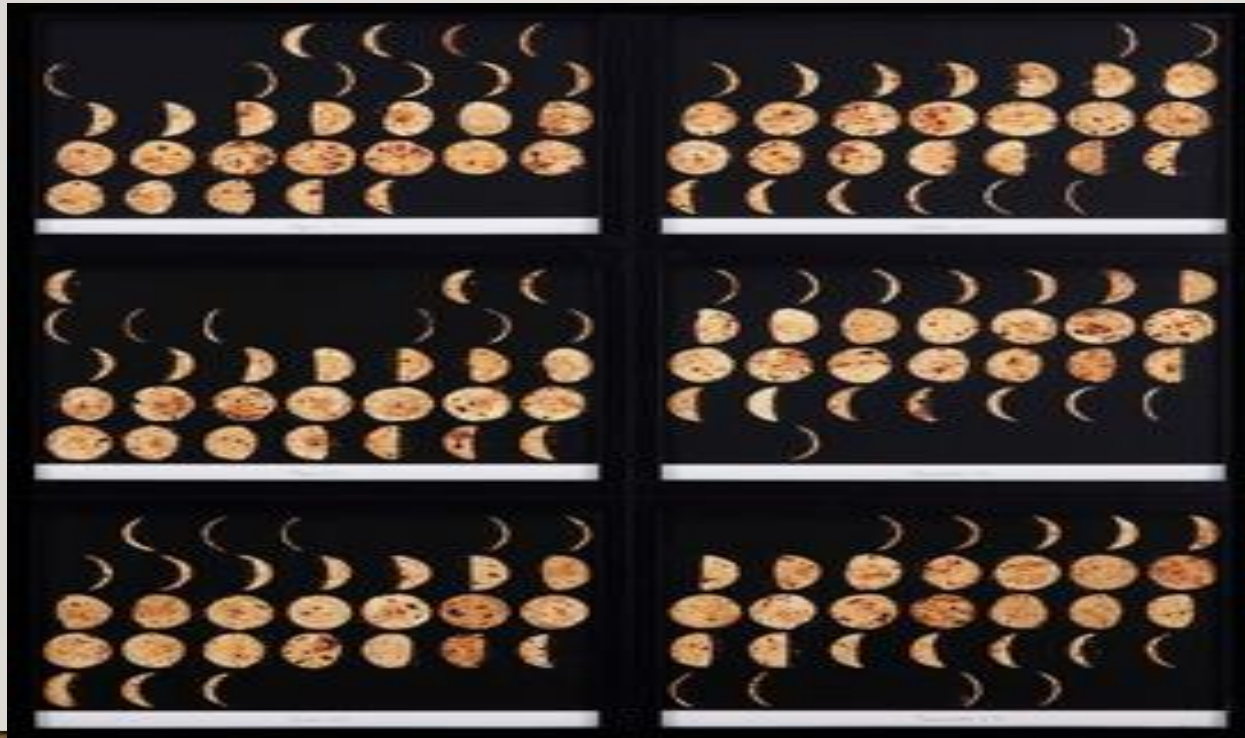
GANESH PYNE - "THE ASSASSIN"

- Ganesh Pyne's work has been described as dark, mysterious and based on mythology and folklore. The Assassin is a powerful piece that shows Pyne's mastery in tempera. This painting is a fascinating exploration of human psychology and mortality because of its intricate details and eerie atmosphere.
-



JITISH KALLAT - "EPILOGUE"

- Jitish Kallat's "Epilogue", a deeply personal piece, reflects on life and death. The installation consists of a series of photographs of Indian bread (rotis) which represent the phases of the moon, and symbolise his father's final meal. Kallat uses everyday objects as a way to communicate profound messages, making him one of India's most innovative artists.



- What are the Principles of Painting?
 - In the 3rd century AD, **Vatsyayana** in his book **Kamasutra** mentioned six main principles/limbs or shadanga of
-

paintings. They are:

- Variety of form - Rupabheda
- The portrayal of likeliness of the subject - Sadrisyan
- Creation of luster and gleam with the colours - Bhava
- Mixing of colours to resemble the effects of modelling - Varnikabhanga
- Proportion of the object or subject - Pramanam
- Immersion of emotions - Lavanyayoganam



-
- The play, **Mudrarakshasa by Vishakhadutta**, also mentions the **names of various paintings or patas**, which are important to understand the different styles of paintings and to observe all the principles of paintings.

PRE-HISTORIC PAINTING

- The pre-historic paintings were generally executed on rocks and these rock engravings were called **Petroglyphs**. The first set of prehistoric paintings was discovered in Bhimbetaka caves in Madhya Pradesh in 1957-58.
- These paintings have been called the '**Zoo Rock Shelter**' because they depict an **elephant, rhinoceros, cattle, snake, spotted deer, barasingha,**

BHIMBETKA ROCK PAINTINGS

- It is located south of Bhopal in the Vidhyan ranges of Madhya Pradesh. The rock shelters have **more than 500 rock paintings**. It was declared a **UNESCO World Heritage Site in 2003**.
 - The oldest paintings are estimated to be 30,000 years old and have survived due to their location deep inside the caves.
- There is marked continuity in occupancy of the caves **from 100,000 BC to 1000 AD** with many paintings being **painted on top of one another**.
- The paintings at Bhimbetka **belong to Upper Paleolithic, Mesolithic, Chalcolithic, early historic and medieval period**. However, most of the paintings belong to the Mesolithic age.
 - **Romanticisation of Daily Chores:** The paintings **generally portray the everyday life** of pre-historic **men often in stick-like human figures**. Various animals like elephants, bison, deer, peacock and snake are depicted.





 Smarthistory
Smarthistory – Bhimbetka cave paint...



 Wikipedia, the free encyclopedia
Bhimbetka rock shelters - Wikipedia



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Bhimbetka Cave Paintings | Prehisto...



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 Asia Research News |
Bhimbetka Cave Paintings ...



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 Gandhisagar Forest Retreat
Ancient Rock Art Wonders of Madhya Pra...



 Explore My Ways
Bhimbetka rock shelters travel gui...

CLASSIFICATION OF INDIAN PAINTINGS

- **Mural Paintings in India**

- The **works on the walls or a solid structure** are referred to as Murals. These have existed in India since ancient times and can be dated between the 10th century BC and the 10th century AD.
- The Mural paintings are **unique because of their sheer size**. They cannot be contained on paper and need to be executed on the walls of large structures, usually caves and temple walls.
- In the ancient period, these were utilised by three major religions: **Buddhism, Jainism and Hinduism**.



SOME OF THE BEST EXAMPLES AJANTA CAVE PAINTINGS:

- **Ajanta caves** , Aurangabad district Maharashtra, were carved in the 4th century AD out of volcanic rocks. It consists of a set of **30 caves, carved in a horse-shoe shape**. These caves are quite popular for their **exquisite mural paintings that took around four to five centuries to complete under the reign of the Mauryan Empire**.
- Murals in cave no. 9 and 10 belong to the Sunga period, while the rest belong to the Gupta period. The walls of the caves have both murals and fresco paintings (painted on wet plaster). **They use tempera style, i.e. use of pigments.**
- The common themes of these paintings range from Jataka stories to life of Buddha to elaborate decorative patterns of flora and fauna.



- The caves were built in two phases, the first starting around the second century BCE and the second occurring from 400 to 650 CE, according to older accounts, or in a brief period of 460–480 CE according to later scholarship
- The Ajanta Caves constitute ancient monasteries (*Viharas*) and worship-halls (*Chaityas*) of different Buddhist traditions carved into a 75-metre (246 ft) wall of rock
- The caves also present paintings depicting the past lives and rebirths of the Buddha, pictorial tales from *Aryasura's Jatakamala*, and rock-cut sculptures of Buddhist deities Textual records suggest that these caves served as a monsoon retreat for monks, as well as a resting site for merchants and pilgrims in ancient India.
- While vivid colours and mural wall paintings were abundant in Indian history as evidenced by historical records, Caves 1, 2, 16 and 17 of Ajanta form the largest corpus of surviving ancient Indian wall-paintings





Holidify
5 Ajanta Caves Painti...



The Concrete Paparazzi
Photography Inside Ajanta Caves ...



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Buddhist Ajanta Caves



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sculpted caves of ajanta ...



ResearchGate
Cave painting at Aja...



Ajanta Heritage & Culture
famous Ajanta Cave art ...



MAP Academy
Ajanta Cave Paintings ...

ELLORA CAVE PAINTINGS:

- The mural paintings in the **Ellora caves** are found in five caves, mostly limited to the Kailasa temple. These **murals were done in two phases**.
 - The first phase paintings were done during the carving of the caves, while the second phase ones were done several centuries later.
- The **earlier paintings show Vishnu** with his consort Lakshmi borne through the clouds by Garuda, the celestial bird. The **later paintings, made in Gujarati** style, depict the procession of Shaiva holy men.

THE ELLORA CAVES

- The **Ellora Caves** are a UNESCO World Heritage Site in Aurangabad, India.
- It is one of the largest rock-cut cave complexes in the world, with artwork dating from AD 600–1000, including Hindu, Buddhist, and Jain caves
- The complex is a leading example of Indian rock-cut architecture, and several are not strictly "caves" in that they have no roof.
- Cave 16 features the largest single monolithic rock excavation in the world, the Kailash temple, a chariot-shaped monument dedicated to the god Shiva.
- The Kailash temple excavation also features sculptures depicting various Hindu deities as well as relief panels summarizing the two major Hindu epics.



HubPages
Ancient Indian Art, Arc...

Britannica
Ellora Caves | Ancient Temples, ...

ResearchGate
Cave painting at Ellora Caves ...

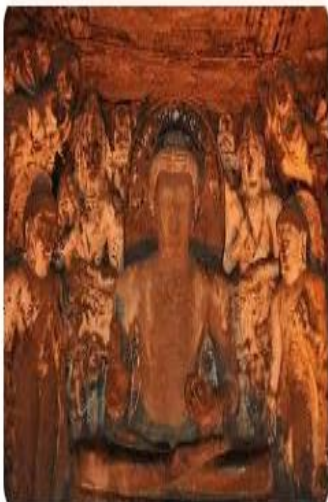
Alamy
Ellora Caves kailas...

The Times of India
Ajanta and Ellora caves | TimesTra...

Sahapedia
A Riddle called Ellora | ...

Pranjal Arts
Ajanta Ellora Cave...

Wikipedia, the free ...
Ellora Caves - Wiki...



- **Armamalai Cave Paintings:**
 - **Armamalai Cave Paintings** are situated in the Vellore district of Tamil Nadu, these natural caves were **converted into a Jain temple in the 8th century**. Unbaked mud structures are located within the cave, which acts like a place of rest for Jain saints.
 - The **beautiful colourful paintings on the walls and roof depict the tales of Astathik Palakas** (deities protecting eight corners) and Jainism.





Wikipedia, the free encyclopedia
Armamalai Cave - Wikipedia



cpreecenvs.nic.in
Armamalai Cave



tnarch.gov.in
Armamalai Cave Malaiy...



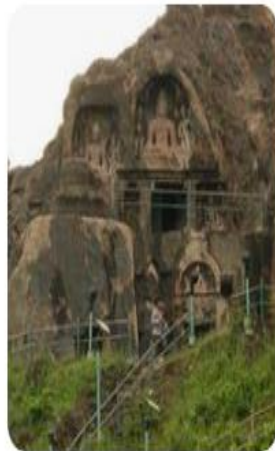
A Wandering Heritager
A Wandering Heritager: ARMAMA...



Wikimedia Commons
Jain Paintings, Armamalai Cave...



the light baggage
A visit to the ancient Jain caves



Monuments - Tamilnadu ...
Monuments - Tamilnadu...



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Armamalai Cave is ...



IndiaNetzone
Armamalai Cave



Rishi Upsc
Armamalai Cave Paintings – Indian ...



Tripadvisor
Armamalai Cave (2025) - All You Need to...



Wikiwand
Armamalai Cave - Wikiwand



the light baggage
A visit to the ancient Jain caves



News24
7 World Famous C...

JOGIMARA CAVE PAINTINGS:

- **Jogimara Cave Paintings** is an artificially carved-out cave located in the Surguja district of Chattisgarh. It is dated back around 1000-300 BC and has a few paintings and inscriptions of a love story in Brahmi script.
- The cave is **said to be an attachment to the amphitheatre** and paintings were made to decorate the room.



Wikipedia, the free encyclopedia
Armamalai Cave - Wikipedia



cpreecenvs.nic.in
Armamalai Cave



tnarch.gov.in
Armamalai Cave Malayi...



A Wandering Heritager
A Wandering Heritager: ARMAMA...



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Jain Paintings, Armamalai Cave...



the light baggage
A visit to the ancient Jain caves



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MINIATURE PAINTINGS

- The word 'miniature' is derived from the Latin word 'Minium', which means red lead paint. **This painting was used in illuminated manuscripts** during the Renaissance period.
- It is generally confused with the word minimum, which would mean that they were **small in size**.
- The Indian subcontinent has long traditions of these miniature paintings and many schools developed that have differences in composition and perspective.
- **Miniatures are small and detailed paintings.**
- The painting **should not be larger than 25 square inches**.
- The subject of the painting should be **painted in not more than 1/6th of the actual size**.
- They usually have bulging eyes, pointed nose and slim waist.



- **Early Miniature:** Early miniature paintings were initially less refined, featuring minimal decoration. Over time, they evolved to include more detailed embellishments, ultimately becoming similar to today's miniature paintings—representing simply the early phase of this art form.
- They were often painted for either books or albums, on perishable material including paper, palm leaves and cloth. ~~These paintings developed between the 8th and 12th centuries and can be attributed to the eastern and western regions.~~
- **Two prominent schools of early miniature paintings are:**
- **Pala School of Art:** This school was flourishing during 750-1150 AD. These paintings are generally found as a part of Buddhist manuscripts and were generally executed on palm leaf or vellum paper.
 - These paintings are characterised by sinuous lines and subdued tones of the background imagery. There are lonely single figures in the paintings and one rarely finds group paintings.
 - The proponents of the Vajrayana school of Buddhism also used and patronised these paintings.
- **Apabhramsa School of Art:** This school traces its origin to Gujarat and Mewar region in Rajasthan. It was the predominant school of painting in western India during 11th to 15th century.
 - The most common themes of these paintings were Jain and in the later period the Vaishanava School appropriated them too.



MINIATURE ART DURING DELHI SULTANATE:

- These paintings tried to bring together the Persian elements of their origins with the Indian traditional elements.
- The finest example from this period is the **Nimatnama (a book on cookery) during the reign of Nasir Shah who ruled over Mandu.**

MUGHAL ERA MINIATURE PAINTING:

- The paintings **made in the Mughal period** had a distinctive style as they were drawn from Persian antecedents.
 - There was a change in colour palette, themes and forms. The **focus shifted from depicting the god to glorifying the ruler and showing his life.**
 - They focused on hunting scenes, historical events and other court related paintings.
 - The painters were supposed to concentrate on ensuring the accuracy of line drawings. Except for religious paintings, the Mughals were known for their diverse themes.
 - They brought the **technique of foreshortening** to the Indian painter's repertoire. Under this technique, **"objects were drawn in a way that they look closer and smaller than they really are."**
 - The styles of **paintings under the successive rulers are as follows:**



Mughal Emperor	Contribution to Painting	Notable Artistic Achievements
Babur	Patronized Persian artist Bihzad for Mughal family tree illustrations.	Limited direct involvement due to a short reign.
Humayun	Great patron of the arts, introduced Persian influence to Mughal paintings and created illustrated albums.	Promoted Persian artistic styles and influenced Mughal painting.
Akbar	Established Tasvir Khana, a formal artistic studio with salaried artists. Created the illustrated manuscript "Tutinama." Encouraged calligraphy in paintings.	Prominent manuscripts: Tutinama (Tale of a Parrot), Hamzanama, Anvar-i-Suhaili, and Gulistan of Sadi.
Jahangir	Reached the zenith of Mughal painting. Preferred naturalistic themes like flora and fauna (birds, animals, trees, flowers). Introduced the trend of decorated margins around paintings.	Jahangir was a skilled artist himself. Known for naturalistic paintings of the Zebra, turkey, and the cock.
Shah Jahan	Attempted to reduce liveliness and introduce stillness, influenced by European art. Encouraged the use of pencils for sketching. Increased the use of gold and silver in paintings and preferred brighter color palettes.	Artistic style marked by European influence and a shift towards stillness and opulence.



- **Regional Schools of Art:** Regional Schools of Art remembered their Indian roots and a penchant for colourful paintings as opposed to the more naturalistic Mughal style. The different schools and styles that developed in this period were:
- **Rajasthani Schools of Painting:** It is more or less synonymous to the Rajput school of paintings. There are several sub- genres of Rajasthani paintings which correspond to their princely state of origin.
 - **Mewar School of Painting:** Mewar painting is **dominated by the extraordinary figure of Sahibdin**. This period of Mewari painting focuses on Sahibdin's depiction of literary texts – the Rasikapriya, the Ramayana and the Bhagavata Purana.
 - The unique point of this period is the **extraordinary 'tamasha' paintings** that show court ceremonial and city views in unprecedented detail.
 - **Kishangarh School of Painting:** Paintings at Kishangarh is associated with the most romantic legends – Sawant Singh and his **beloved Bani Thani**, and of the intertwining of lives and myths, romance and bhakti. It is sometimes argued that the women in 'bani thani' is said to **resemble the character of Radha**.



- **Pahari Styles of Painting:** This style of painting **developed in the sub-himalayan states** that were also under the umbrella of Mughal over lordship. Hence, the Pahari paintings can be grouped into two groups:
-

- **Jammu or Dogra School:** Northern Series
- **Basholi and Kangra School:** Southern Series
- A typical Pahari painting would bring several figures into the canvas. Each figure is different in composition, colour and pigmentation.
- **Basholi School:** This was the early phase and expressive faces with a receding hairline and big eyes that are shaped like lotus petals characterise it. These paintings **use a lot of primary colours, i.e. red, yellow and green.** They used the Mughal technique of painting on clothing but developed their own styles and techniques.
- **Kangra School:** These paintings were marked with a sensuality and intelligence that the other schools lacked. **The very famous group of paintings is the ‘Twelve Months’** where the artist tried to bring forth the effect of the twelve months on the emotions of human beings.



- **Ragamala Paintings:** Ragamala Paintings are a series of illustrative paintings from medieval India based on **Ragamala or the 'Garland of Ragas'**, depicting various Indian musical Ragas. They stand as a classical example of the amalgamation of art, poetry and classical music in medieval India.
-
- **Ragamala paintings were created in most Indian schools of painting**, starting in the 16th and 17th centuries and are today named accordingly, as **Pahari Ragamala, Rajasthan or Rajput Ragamala, Deccan Ragamala, and Mughal Ragamala.**
 - In these painting, **each raga is personified by a colour describing the story of a hero and heroine** (nayaka and nayika) in a particular mood. it also **elucidates the season and the time of day and night** in which a particular raga is to be sung.
 - Moreover, many paintings also demarcate the specific Hindu deities attached with the raga, like Bhairava or Bhairavi to Shiva, Sri to Devi etc. **The six principal ragas present in the Ragamala are Bhairava, Deepak, Sri, Malkaush, Megha and Hindola.**

MINIATURES IN SOUTH INDIA

- The trend of making miniature paintings in the South Indian states is different from the north Indian schools owing to the **heavy use of gold in these paintings**. Furthermore, they concentrated on painting divine creatures much more than **painting the rulers** who patronized them. Some of the **major schools are**:
- **Tanjore Paintings**: The Thanjavur or Tanjore School is **famous for the special style of decorative paintings**. The **Maratha rulers patronized** them during the 18th century.
 - These paintings are unique as they are **mostly created on glass and board** instead of cloth and vellum preferred in north India. Use of brilliant colour patterns and the liberal use of gold leaf are uniqueness of these paintings.
 - They used many types of **gemstones and cut glasses for embellishments to create larger than life images**.
 - These paintings **reached their zenith under the patronage of Sarfoji Maharaj** who was a great patron of arts.

MINIATURE PAINTINGS

- In eastern India, the principal centres of artistic and intellectual activities of the Buddhist religion were Nalanda, Odantapuri, Vikramshila and Somarpura situated in the Pala kingdom (Bengal and Bihar). Miniature painting from this region survives from the 10th century.
- Miniature painting is a small, intricate form of art characterized by detailed brushwork on surfaces like paper, palm leaves, or ivory. Originating from traditions such as Persian, Mughal, and Rajput art, these paintings are typically small in size, often designed to be read or viewed in books, albums, or manuscripts. Despite their small scale, they are known for their depth and detail, created with fine-tipped brushes and natural pigments like ground minerals and gold dust





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MUGHAL PAINTING

- Mughal painting is a style of Indian painting, generally confined to illustrations on the book and done in miniatures, and which emerged, developed and took shape during the period of the Mughal Empire between the 16th and 19th centuries.
- The Mughal style was heavily influenced by Persian miniatures, and in turn influenced several Indian styles, including the Rajput, Pahari and Deccan styles of painting.
- Akbar's reign (1556–1605) ushered a new era in Indian miniature painting
- He was the first monarch who established in India an atelier under the supervision of two Persian master artists, Mir Sayyed Ali and Abdus Samad
- Tuti-Nama was an early Mughal work from the mid 16th Century



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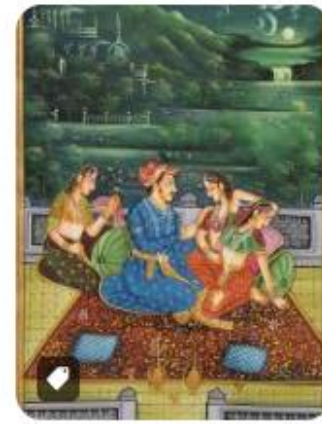
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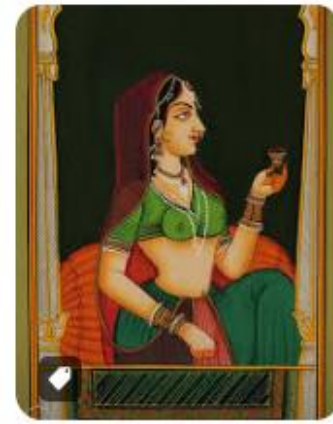
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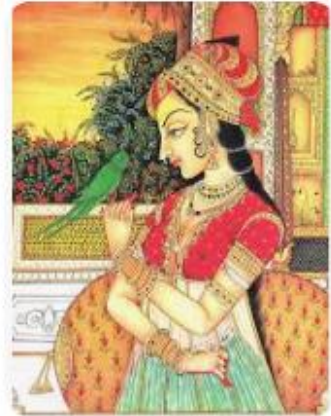
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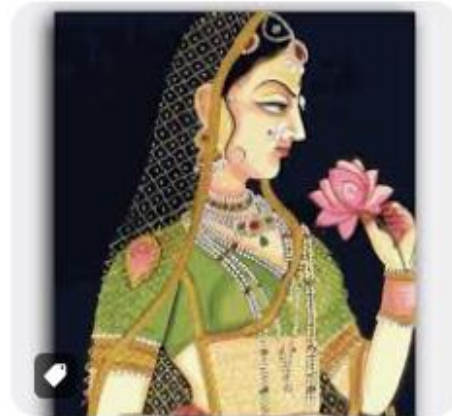
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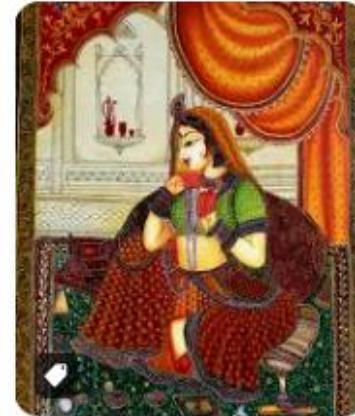
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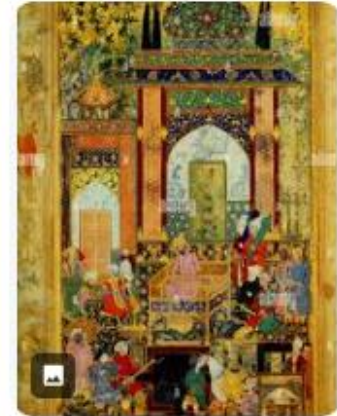
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Cultura
Mughal

- Akbar *Hamzanama* manuscript, which according to the court historian Badayuni was started in 1567 and completed in 1582
 - The *Hamzanama* an epic Persian account of Amir Hamza, an uncle of the Prophet, were illustrated by Mir Sayyid Ali
-
- Jahangir encouraged artists to paint portraits and durbar scenes.^[32]
 - His most talented portrait painters were Ustad Mansur Abul Hasan and Bishandas.
 - Shah Jahan (1627–1658) continued the patronage of painting.^[32] Some of the famous artists of the period were Mohammad Faqirullah Khan, Mir Hashim, Muhammad Nadir, Bichitr, Chitarman, Anupchhatar, Manohar and Honhar.
 - Aurangzeb had no taste for fine arts



MYSORE PAINTINGS:

- These paintings were **patronised by the rulers of the Mysore province** and continued in the British period too.
 - The **major theme** of the Mysore paintings is the **depiction of Hindu gods and goddesses**. The unique part of these paintings is that **they had two or more figures in each painting and one figure predominates all the others in size and colour**.
 - These paintings use the technique of the '**gesso paste**', which is a mixture of **zinc oxide and Arabic gum**. This gives a particular base to the painting that develops sheen on the background.
 - They counter it with the **use of muted colours that are not so bright so as to counteract the background**.

MODERN PAINTINGS

- **Company Paintings:** In the colonial period, a **hybrid style of painting** emerged that combined the elements of Rajput, Mughal and other Indian styles of painting with European elements (styles and techniques).
 - These paintings **evolved when the British Company officers employed painters who had been trained in Indian styles**. Hence, they **mixed their employers European tastes with their Indian training**. This was **called the 'Company Paintings'**.
 - They were distinguished by the **use of water colour** and in technique by the **appearance of linear perspective and shading**.
 - **Lord Impey and Marquess Wellesley patronised the painters;** several painters were engaged in painting the 'exotic' flora and fauna of India.

-

BAZAAR PAINTINGS:

- This school was also **influenced by the European encounter** in India. They were **different from the Company paintings** as that school mixed **European techniques and themes** with Indian ones.
 - The **Bazaar school** did not take any Indian influence but took the **Roman and Greek influence**. They made the **painters to copy the Greek and Roman statues**.
 - This school was **prevalent in the Bengal and Bihar region**. A part from the Greco-roman heritage, **they made paintings on everyday bazaar that showed Indian bazaars with European background**.
 - One of the most famous genres was of depicting **Indian courtesans dancing before the British officials**. They also painted religious themes but the **figures of Indian Gods and Goddesses** with more than two axes and elephant faces like that of Lord Ganesha were **prohibited as they deviated from the European notion of natural human figurine**.

BENGAL SCHOOL OF ART:

- The Bengal school is supposed to have a **reactionary approach to the existing styles of paintings** in the 1940s –1960s. This school is unique as **they use simple colours**. The idea of the **Bengal school came up with the works of Abhanindranath Tagore** in the early 20th century. He tried to **incorporate Swadeshi values in Indian art and tried to reduce the influence of Western art style among artists**.
- He is known for his **painting Bharat Mata and various Mughal-themed paintings**.
- The other notable painter of this school is **Nandlal Bose**. He was also entrusted with **the task of illuminating the original document of the Constitution of India**.

CUBIST STYLE OF PAINTING:

- The cubist movement of Painting took its **inspiration from the European Cubist movement.**
 - Under this style, the **objects were broken, analysed and then reassembled.** The artist reconstructed this process on the canvas through the use of abstract art forms.
 - They tried to **achieve the perfect balance between line and colour.**
 - One of the most popular **cubist artists in India was M.F Hussain**, who made a series of paintings **called the 'Personification of Romance'.**

-

PAINTING STYLES OF INDIA

Painting styles of India

From sources across the web



Warli



Gond



Kalamkari



Phad



Kalighat painting



Kerala murals



Patachitra



Madhubani paintings



Cheriyal scrolls



Miniature painting



Pattachitra



Pichwai



Tanjore painting



Madhubani painting



Mysore Painting



Rajasthani Miniature paintings



Kalamezhuthu



Mughal



Saura art



Tanjore



Thangka paintings



Bhil



Chittara painting



Rajput painting

WARLI



- **Warli painting** is tribal art mostly created by the tribal people from the North Sahyadri Range in Maharashtra, India. Warli paintings exist in cities such as Dahanu, Talasari, Jawhar, Palghar and Mokhada and originated in Maharashtra, where it is still practiced today.
- The paintings are usually done on mud walls, using a white pigment made from rice paste and water. They depict daily life, farming activities, animals, and natural elements in simple geometric shapes. Traditionally, Warli art is created by women and is often linked with rituals and celebrations

PHAD PAINTING

a style of religious scroll painting and folk painting, practiced in Rajasthan state of India

This style of painting is traditionally done on a long piece of cloth or canvas, known as *phad*. The narratives of the folk deities of Rajasthan, mostly of Pabuji and Devnarayan are depicted on the *phad*s.

The Bhopas, the priest-singers traditionally carry the painted *phads* along with them and use these as the mobile temples of the folk deities, who are worshipped by the Rebari community of the region.

The *phads* of Pabuji are normally about 15 feet (4.6 m) in length, while the *phads* of Devnarayan are normally about 30 feet long. Traditionally the *phads* are painted with vegetable colors.





PATACHITRA PAINTING OF ODISHA

- a general term for traditional, cloth-based scroll painting, based in the eastern Indian states of Odisha and West Bengal as well as parts of Bangladesh.
- Patachitra art form is known for its intricate details as well as mythological narratives and folktales inscribed in it. Pattachitra is one of the ancient artworks of Odisha, originally created for ritual use and as souvenirs for pilgrims to Puri, as well as other temples in Odisha
- Patachitras are a component of an ancient Bengali narrative art, originally serving as a visual device during the performance of a song



TANJORE PAINTING

- a centuries-old tradition of handcrafted Indian paintings. Each artwork is handcrafted with **24-karat gold leaf**, semi-precious stones, and vibrant natural colors, these masterpieces bring spirituality and cultural richness into your home or office. Browse our curated collection of Tanjore Paintings Online and bring home an authentic piece of Thanjavur art today.
- “Beauty shines with a light from beyond itself.” In the tradition of Tanjore art- glistening with its golden and jeweled embellishments and the purifying presence of the great divine, this statement finds an expression. Drawing from the opulent treasure of Indian religious traditions, Tanjore or Thanjavur paintings are proof of India’s devotion to its culture, which is turned into an unforgettable visual experience encased within a refined wood frame by the Tanjore artists.



SAURA PAINTING

Saura painting is a style of wall mural paintings associated with the saura tribals of the state of odisha in india.

These paintings, also called *ikons* (or *ekons*) are visually similar to warli paintings and hold religious significance for the sauras

SAURA PAINTING



KALAMKARI

- **Kalamkari**, also commonly spelled as **qalamkari**, is an ancient textile printing art, that finds its roots in the Indian state of Andhra Pradesh.
- Kalamkari gained popularity in the South India during the reign of Vijayanagara Empire.
- *Kalam* implies 'pen' and *Kari* means 'art', a name given by the Mughals when they discovered the art during their reign over the Deccan region. Only natural dyes are used in *Kalamkari*, which involves twenty-three steps
- There are two main styles of Kalamkari in India. The hand painted style that is largely practised in the town of Srikalahasti and block printed that is practised in the town of Machilipatnam, both located in Andhra Pradesh



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KALIGHAT PAINTINGS OR BENGAL PAT

- The Kalighat painting style was developed around Mid-19th century in the neighbourhood of Kali Temple in Calcutta. These drawings on paper were done by a group known as “patuas” hence the name Kalighata Pata. They depicted scenes of everyday life and mythological deities in a simple yet captivating manner and developed into the popular kalighat style of painting. Kalighat painters predominantly use earthy Indian colours like indigo, ochre, Indian red, grey, blue and white. The swift, seamless, free-flowing outline is a distinguished characteristic of Kalighat style of paintings. This painting style has inspired many artists, the most famous being Jamini Roy, one of the celebrated artist in Indian art.





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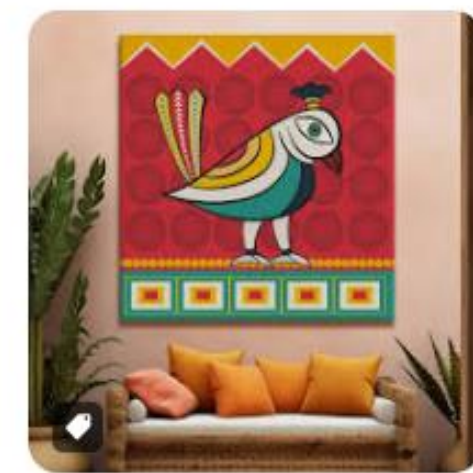
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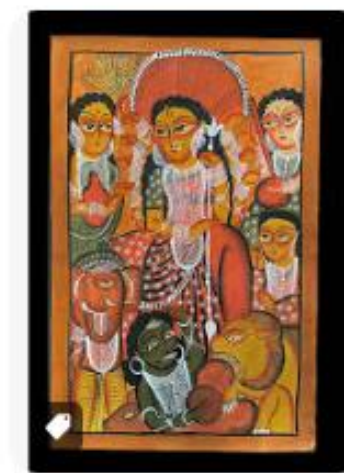
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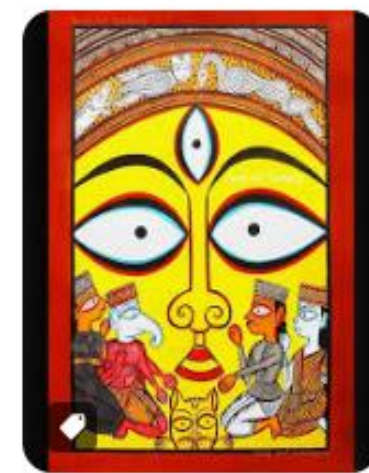
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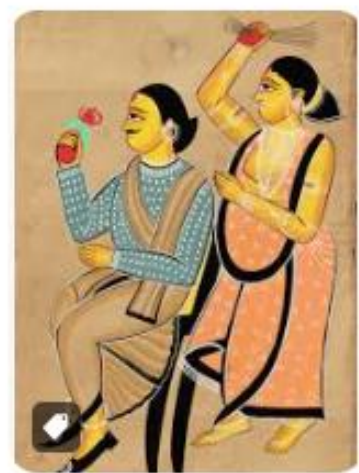
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GOND PAINTING

- These vibrant paintings created with a series of intricately arranged dots and dashes were developed by the Gondi tribe of central India. The tribals recreate mythological tales and oral histories to traditional songs, natural surroundings, important events and rituals in with great intricacy, rich detailing, and bright colors. Traditionally, colors were derived from natural resources like cow dung, plant sap, charcoal, coloured soil, mud, flowers, leaves etc. Gond artists now use commercial water-based colors to paint on paper and canvas. In today's times, Gond art has moved beyond being a tribal art style with nameless artists to having internationally acclaimed artists like Jangarh Singh Shyam, Venkat Shyam, Bhajju Shyam, Durga Bai Vyam to name a few.





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KERALA MURALS

- The vibrant Kerala mural paintings are one of the world's most famous frescos and have deep spiritual roots depicting themes of Hindu mythology, epics, the classic frolics of Krishna as well as the mystic forms of Siva and Shakti. They also recount some legendary heroes of the bygone era. This traditional art style dates to the seventh and eighth century AD and is characterised by vivacious imagery, bold strokes, and vivid colours. Ochre-red, yellow- ochre, bluish- green, white and pure colors are predominantly used in Kerala mural painting.





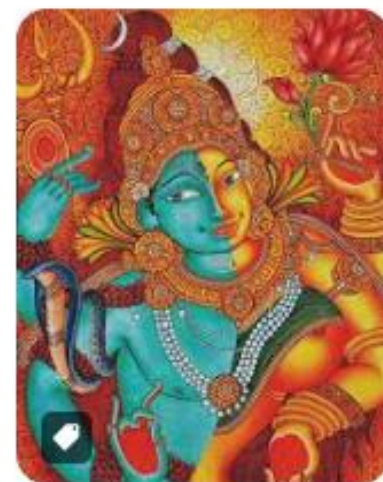
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PICHHWAI

- The Indian art of Pichwai originated as wall hangings behind the main deity in Krishna temples in Nathdwara Rajsamand district of the state of Rajasthan. They narrate stories related to Lord Krishna. Gradually with commercialisation secular themes are also incorporated in the Picchwai style of painting. Picchwais are colourful and intricate works of art with concealed symbolism in the artistic motifs. This distinct devotional art practice has passed from one generation to another and a fine example of spirituality in art.





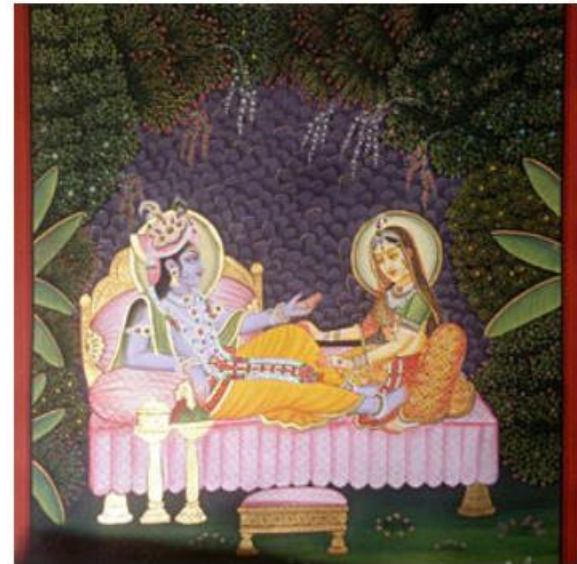
Pichwai Painting

By Unknown Artist



Pichwai Painting

By Lokesh



Pichwai Painting

By Unknown Artist

MADHUBANI PAINTINGS

- It is named after the Madhubani district of Bihar India, which is where it originated and is the most active centre of production.
- Jitwarpur, Ranti and Rasidpur are the three most notable cities associated with the tradition and evolution of Madhubani art
- The art was traditionally practiced by female members
- Artists create these paintings using a variety of mediums, including their own fingers, or twigs, brushes, nib-pens, and matchsticks. The paint is created using natural dyes and pigments such as ochre and lampblack are used for reddish brown and black respectively
- The paintings are characterized by their eye-catching geometrical patterns. There is ritual content for particular occasions, such as birth or marriage and festivals, such as Holi, Surya Shasti, Kali Puja, Upanayana, and Durga Puja.





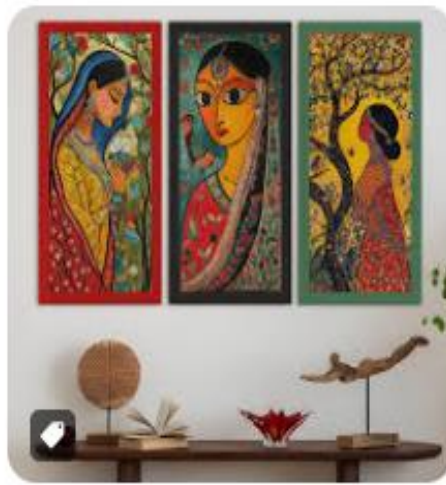
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CHITTARA PAINTING

- Originating from the heart of Southern India, the traditional art form known as Chittara (or Hase Chitra) stands as a remarkable cultural phenomenon within the Deeveru community. The term "Chittara" draws its essence from the Kannada word "Chitra," resonating with the notions of "picture" and "painting." Nestled around the enchanting village of Sirevanthe, Sagar, approximately 360 kilometers from Bangalore in Karnataka, this vibrant tradition thrives amidst the breathtaking landscapes of the Western Ghats





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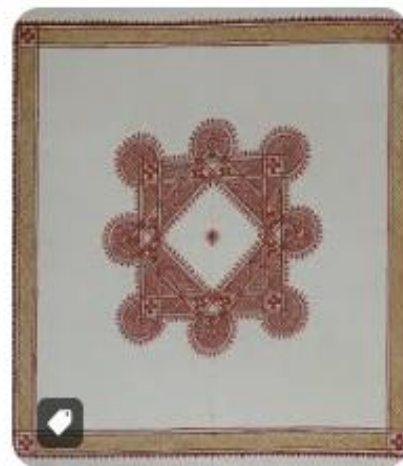
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INDIAN TREATISES ON PAINTING

- *Chitrasutras*, chapters 35–43 within the Hindu text *Vishnudharmottara Purana*
 - *Chitralaksana* of Nagnajit
 - *Samarangana Sutradhara* (mostly architecture treatise, contains a large section on paintings)
 - *Aparajitaprccha* (mostly architecture treatise, contains a large section on paintings)
 - *Manasollasa* (an encyclopedia, contains chapters on paintings)
 - *Abhilashitārtha chinatamani*
 - *Sivatatva ratnakara*
 - *Chitra Kaladruma*
 - *Silpa ratna*
 - *Narada silpa*
 - *Sarasvati silpa*
 - *Prajapati silpa*
 - *Kasyapa silpa*
-



MURALS

- There are known more than 20 locations around India containing murals from this period, mainly natural caves and rock-cut chambers. These include the caves of Ajanta, Bagh, Sittanavasal, Armamalai Cave (Tamil Nadu), Kailasanatha temple in Ellora Caves, Ramgarh and Sitabinji.
- Murals from this period depict mainly religious themes of Buddhist, Jain and Hindu religions
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